

Q What is a healthy, balanced diet and how can I eat enough nutrients?

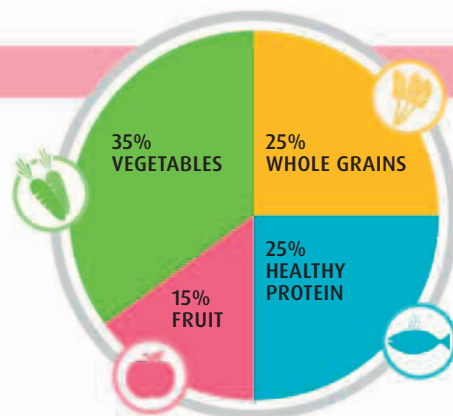
A healthy diet is comprised of the right balance of nutritious foods from several main food groups: protein, fruit, vegetables, unrefined carbohydrates, and healthy fats. You should eat foods from these groups in their most natural, unprocessed state to receive the maximum number of nutrients.

Whether you are still at the stage of planning conception or are already pregnant, you need to make sure your diet includes the correct balance of the main food groups. A balanced diet allows your body to store enough of the right nutrients for a healthy pregnancy and feel in peak condition. Eating in a consistent and measured way also helps you to

keep your weight within healthy limits, which is a factor for successful conception. Once you become pregnant, the benefit of eating a balanced diet is that you will be supplying your body with the best possible diet for fetal growth and development and providing yourself with enough energy to deal with the pregnancy.

HEALTHY EATING

Eat a variety of foods from each of these groups in the right proportions for optimum nutritional benefits at every meal. The breakdown of these healthy foods equates to approximately five to six portions of fresh vegetables, two portions of fresh fruit, and three portions each of protein and unrefined carbohydrates per day.



FLUIDS AND FATS

» **Stay hydrated:** often feelings of hunger are in fact symptoms of thirst. Water is best.

» **Enjoy healthy fats:** dairy (also a source of calcium) and oils (such as olive oil) are good for you in moderate amounts.



VEGETABLES

The more vegetables—and the greater the variety—the better. Steaming is the best way to prepare vegetables if you don't eat them raw.



FRUIT

Eat fresh fruit of all colors. Fruit contains fructose, a type of sugar, so a couple of portions a day will give you fiber and vitamins without overloading on sugar.



HEALTHY PROTEINS

Choose fish, poultry, beans, and nuts; limit red meat and avoid bacon and processed meats. Steam, grill, or bake fish and meat.



WHOLE GRAINS

Eat a variety of whole grains (such as whole-wheat bread, whole-grain pasta, and brown rice). Limit or avoid refined grains (such as white rice and white bread).

Fresh fruit and vegetables

When it comes to fruit and vegetables, the more colorful the better. Strong color is a sign that they are rich in vitamins and minerals, and high in protective antioxidants, which help to fight free radicals in the body. Eat a wide color range of vegetables and fruit for the maximum benefits.

